



Barrier Breakers, March 20, 2026. Students from across Northeast Ohio before the first pitch of the morning.

Reach 8,000 students. Put the top 250 in one room.

Barrier Breakers is FinMango's one-day innovation challenge for Northeast Ohio high schoolers, heading into its fourth year. In 2026, powered by Valmark, we promoted it to roughly **8,000 students in 25+ high schools** across the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas through our in-person classroom programming over the academic year. About **250 of the top students** from those classrooms showed up on March 20 to pitch real solutions to the costs that hold families back. For 2027 we are asking Valmark to return as platinum sponsor at \$25,000. The details are on page 3.

8,000

About 8,000 students reached in person across 25+ high schools in the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas, where the event was promoted

250

About 250 of the top students from those classrooms competed on event day

\$20K+

Awarded in 2026 as cash to winning teams, grants to their schools, and scholarships

How the pipeline worked

In the classroom. FinMango teaches in-person financial education in 25+ high schools across the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas, reaching about 8,000 students over the academic year. That is where students first hear about Barrier Breakers.

The build. Teams of one to three pick a real barrier, such as transportation, housing, healthcare, or financial literacy, and build a solution to bring to the event.

Event day. Sixty-second pitches to a three-judge panel in the morning. Five finalists present to the whole room at Demo Day in the afternoon, and the cash goes to the teams.

2026 at a glance

Event date	March 20, 2026
Students competing	About 250
Platinum sponsor	Valmark · \$25,000
Awarded to students and schools	\$20,000+
Demo Day finalists	5 teams
1st place award	\$7,500 cash, scholarship & school grant
Minimum finalist award	\$1,250

Valmark on the day

Valmark was the presenting sponsor of Barrier Breakers 2026 and was visible to every student in the building, from check-in through the awards.

- \$25,000 platinum sponsorship funded the prize pool
- Two Valmark judges on the Demo Day panel
- Valmark table and banner on the gallery floor all day
- Valmark judges presented awards alongside the panel

Where the money went

Barrier Breakers 2026 raised \$30,000 in total: \$25,000 from Valmark as platinum sponsor and \$5,000 from two additional sponsors to help cover expenses. More than \$20,000 went out as awards. The rest paid for the day itself: breakfast and lunch for 250 students plus their teachers and judges, materials, and the space.

In 2026, part of each award was a scholarship usable only at the host university, and only in its college of business. Students who enrolled anywhere else, or chose a different major, never received that portion of their prize. That will not happen with sponsor funds in 2027. None of Valmark's sponsorship goes to scholarships. It goes to cash prizes and the event itself. We still want a scholarship component, and we are working toward one that students can use at any university, or one that a university partner awards on top of the cash prizes and funds separately.

Valmark, platinum sponsor	\$25,000
Two additional sponsors	\$5,000
Total raised	\$30,000
Awards: team cash, school grants, scholarships	\$20,000+
The day: food, materials, space	Remainder



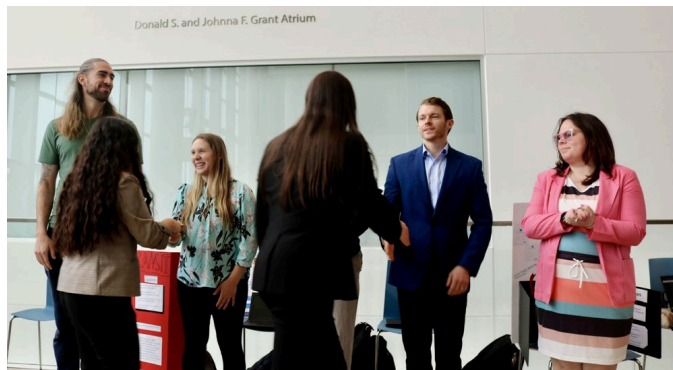
Valmark's table on the gallery floor, where students stopped between judging rounds.



The gallery round: sixty seconds to make the case, then questions from a judge.



Demo Day: five finalists present for five minutes each in front of every student in the room.



Awards: cash to the teams and a handshake from the judges, including Valmark's.

Sponsoring Barrier Breakers 2027

We are asking Valmark to return as the platinum presenting sponsor of Barrier Breakers 2027 at \$25,000, the same level as 2026. The day keeps the same rhythm, a morning of pitches at the tables and Demo Day in the afternoon, but we have simplified the format for 2027: one pipeline for every team, no tracks to declare, one rubric for both rounds, and cash straight to the student teams. With no scholarship component, more of each sponsor dollar reaches the students in the room. The invitation list grows: beyond the 25+ schools where FinMango teaches, we plan to invite many more high schools across Northeast Ohio to bring teams.

\$100

Per student in the room, roughly. What Valmark's \$25,000 worked out to across the 250 students who competed in 2026

\$3

Per student reached, roughly, across the 8,000 who heard about Barrier Breakers in a FinMango classroom

25+

High schools in the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas where FinMango teaches in person. The 2027 invitation goes wider

How the \$25,000 is planned

1st place	\$5,000
2nd place	\$3,500
3rd place	\$2,500
4th place	\$2,000
5th place	\$1,500
Honorable mentions, 5 × \$500	\$2,500
Knowledge Track quiz prizes	\$500
The day: breakfast, lunch, materials	\$5,000
Operations and contingency	\$2,500
Total	\$25,000

Approximate. Final amounts post with the host and date. \$17,500 goes to students as prizes, and ten teams leave with cash.

FinMango is a very lean nonprofit with little overhead. The full sponsorship is invested in the event: prizes first, then the operations that make the day run, with a reserve for the unexpected. No scholarships will be funded from sponsorship in 2027.

Sponsorship levels

Platinum · presenting sponsor	\$25,000
"Powered by" naming across the event and the site. Stage time at the awards, a seat on the judging panel, logo on every banner, flyer, and student handout, and first call on the 2028 slot.	
Gold	\$10,000
Funds a Demo Day prize in your name. Logo on the site and event banners, a seat on the judging panel, and a mention from the stage at the awards.	
Silver	\$2,500
Logo on the site and in the printed program, and an invitation to judge.	
Name a prize	Any amount
Fund 1st place or the honorable mentions, and we announce it that way at the awards.	

Where 2027 stands

Date and venue	TBA, host being selected
Judges	Recruiting now, 15 needed
Schools invited	FinMango's 25+ and more
Student applications	Open once the date is set
Prize pool	Announced with sponsors

Scott Glasgow, Founder & Executive Director, FinMango · scott@finmango.org · finmango.org/barrier-breakers

Levels are a starting point. If Valmark would rather fund a named prize, sponsor lunch, or put more of the team on the floor as judges, we will build it around you.